



BEFORE

Only two decades old, photography on the eve of the Civil War had attracted a mass following.

WET-PLATE PHOTOGRAPHY

Wet-plate photography **took hold in the 1850s**. A glass plate coated in collodion (a mixture of bromide and iodides) was dipped in a photosensitive silver nitrate solution and exposed in the camera. Some versions produced single positive images, others negatives from which prints could be made.

WAR PHOTOGRAPHY

Although a few photographs were made during the **War with Mexico** (1847–48), it was in the **Crimean War** (1853–56) that British photographer Roger Fenton, with **more than 350 negatives**, pioneered war photography.

ILLUSTRATED JOURNALS

There were no means of reproducing photographs in journals—the scenes had first to be **engraved on wood**. The mainstays of such popular magazines as *Harper's Weekly* were talented sketch artists, such as Alfred Waud, and the engravers who brought their work to the public.

In January 1858, Mathew Brady opened a photographic studio in Washington, D. C., hiring a young Scotsman named Alexander Gardner to run it. The most famous photographer in America, New York-based Brady had made his name with his portraits of the illustrious men and women of the era.

From portraits to battlegrounds

People saw their likenesses in delicate ambrotypes, each a unique image on glass produced by the wet-plate collodion process and enclosed in a small case, or on popular *cartes de visite*, photographic visiting cards consisting of prints made from negatives and often collected in leather albums.

The business of portraiture was booming by the time the Civil War began. Photographers set up makeshift studios wherever the soldiers pitched their tents. Many portraits taken of soldiers were tintypes. A less expensive alternative to ambrotypes, tintypes were also produced using the wet-plate collodion process, but a thin sheet of blackened iron replaced glass as the image substrate, making them more robust than ambrotypes. They could be mailed safely to sweethearts and loved ones. But whatever the format, hundreds of thousands of small portraits were made during the Civil War. Many